Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services

National Coverage Determination (NCD) 20.8.3

Single Chamber and Dual Chamber Permanent Cardiac Pacemakers

Medicare National Coverage Determinations Manual, Publication 100-03, Chapter 1, Part 1, Section 20.8.3. Effective date: 08/13/2013. Implementation: Transmittal 170 (CR 8525).

Applies to Medicare Advantage plans, including UnitedHealthcare Medicare Advantage, which follow CMS National Coverage Determinations for cardiac pacemakers. Reproduced for software testing from the published NCD and the UF Health Jacksonville compliance checklist of NCD 20.8.3 (10/22/2018); wording reconstructed, verify against cms.gov before clinical use.

A. General

A permanent cardiac pacemaker is an implanted device that provides electrical stimulation to the heart to maintain an adequate heart rate. This section addresses single-chamber and dual-chamber permanent cardiac pacemakers. It does not address biventricular pacemakers, devices that stimulate more than two chambers, devices intended to treat tachyarrhythmias or cardiac dyssynchrony, cardiac resynchronization therapy, or self-contained pacemaker monitors.

B. Nationally Covered Indications

Effective for claims with dates of service on and after August 13, 2013, CMS covers single-chamber or dual-chamber permanent cardiac pacemakers when ALL of the following are met:

1. The patient has documented bradycardia; AND

2. The bradycardia is non-reversible (not due to a transient or correctable cause); AND

3. The bradycardia is symptomatic, with documented symptoms directly attributable to the bradycardia (for example syncope, near-syncope, dizziness, confusion, exercise intolerance, heart failure symptoms); AND

4. The bradycardia is due to ONE of the following:

    • Sinus node dysfunction (sick sinus syndrome, sinus bradycardia, sinus arrest, sinoatrial block, chronotropic incompetence); OR

    • Second-degree and/or third-degree atrioventricular (AV) block.

C. Nationally Non-Covered Indications

Single-chamber and dual-chamber permanent cardiac pacemakers are not covered for the following:

    • Bradycardia due to reversible causes, such as electrolyte abnormalities, medications or drugs, and hypothermia.

    • Asymptomatic first-degree AV block.

    • Asymptomatic sinus bradycardia.

    • Asymptomatic sinoatrial block or sinus arrest.

    • Ineffective atrial contractions (such as chronic atrial fibrillation or flutter, or giant left atrium) without symptomatic bradycardia.

• Asymptomatic second-degree AV block of Mobitz Type I, unless the QRS complexes are prolonged or electrophysiological studies demonstrate that the block is at or beyond the level of the His bundle.

• Syncope of undetermined cause.

• Bradycardia during sleep.

• Right bundle branch block with left axis deviation (and other forms of fascicular or bundle branch blocks) without syncope or other symptoms of intermittent AV block.

• Asymptomatic bradycardia in post-myocardial infarction patients about to initiate long-term beta-blocker drug therapy.

• Frequent or persistent supraventricular tachycardias, except where the pacemaker is specifically for the control of the tachycardia.

• A clinical condition in which pacing takes place only intermittently and briefly, and which is not associated with a reasonable likelihood that pacing needs will become prolonged.

D. Other

All other indications for single-chamber or dual-chamber permanent cardiac pacemakers not otherwise indicated as covered or non-covered above remain at local Medicare Administrative Contractor discretion.

Billing and Coding

CPT / HCPCS	Description	Status
33206	Insertion of new or replacement of permanent pacemaker with transvenous electrode(s), atrial	Covered when criteria met
33207	Insertion of new or replacement of permanent pacemaker with transvenous electrode(s), ventricular	Covered when criteria met
33208	Insertion of new or replacement of permanent pacemaker with transvenous electrode(s), atrial and ventricular	Covered when criteria met
C1785	Pacemaker, dual chamber, rate-responsive (implantable)	Covered when criteria met
C1786	Pacemaker, single chamber, rate-responsive (implantable)	Covered when criteria met
C2619	Pacemaker, dual chamber, non rate-responsive (implantable)	Covered when criteria met
C2620	Pacemaker, single chamber, non rate-responsive (implantable)	Covered when criteria met
33227–33229, 33233	Pulse generator removal/replacement	MAC discretion

Diagnosis codes and modifier requirements are specified in Local Coverage Article A54926. Documentation should include the rhythm diagnosis, the symptoms attributed to the bradycardia and their correlation with the rhythm, and the exclusion of reversible causes (including review of rate-slowing medications and metabolic workup).

Related

• NCD 20.8.1 Cardiac Pacemaker Evaluation Services

• NCD 20.8.2 Self-Contained Pacemaker Monitors

• NCD 10.6 Anesthesia in Cardiac Pacemaker Surgery

• Local Coverage Article A54926

Source: cms.gov Medicare Coverage Database, NCD 20.8.3 (ncdid=238, version 3) and UF Health Jacksonville, Cardiac Pacemakers Single/Dual Chamber NCD 20.8.3 Checklist (10/22/2018).